

Afshan Fathima shows us that there is a way to break the chains

At 23, a young woman from Anna Nagar, Chennai, never imagined a future in sports, let alone MMA. Yet today, she's among the **sport's elite.**

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Afshan Fathima walked away from her very first bout of the 2024 IMMAF World Championships in Uzbekistan last week not only with a win but also with a prodigious, rapidly darkening contusion under her eye. Although the injury was caused by an accidental headbutt rather than a punch from her opponent, many thought it meant the end of her campaign in the women's strawweight division (52.2 kg) at her debut World Championship.

"Everyone who saw me thought I wasn't going to be declared medically fit to take part in the next bout. But I did make it. And then after I won that bout, everyone thought my injury was not going to let me compete in the next bout. After every bout I fought, the other fighters thought I wasn't going to be able to make the

next round because of how big the swelling had gotten. But I kept doing this. There was no way I was going to quit," she says.

By the time Afshan's campaign at the IMMAF World Championships ended, she had gone further than any other Indian — reaching the final — at the premier global amateur competition in mixed martial arts. Amongst her wins was a guillotine choke submission of Ireland's Lisa Murtagh, who trains at the prestigious SB Gym — with the same team as former UFC champion Connor McGregor — and picked up a decision win over reigning World champion Matilda Bachurina of Kazakhstan in the semifinals.

Afshan, however, couldn't return from the competition with the gold medal she had hoped for. She ended up losing the final by a narrow points decision to Isabel Calvo of Spain. "Unfortunately, the day of my final coincided with the start of my period. It was pretty bad. I was puking and had really bad cramps. I wasn't anything close to 100 percent," she says. Afshan says

Afshan says she had to save up for a year in order to pay for her fight camp, nutrition, travel and competition fees for her first IMMAF World Championships this year.